aggravate Soviet-American relations before the November elections. “The President felt himself deceived, and deceived intentionally,” he said to Dobrynin. “He is convinced of that even now. It was for him a great disappointment, or, speaking directly, a heavy blow to everything in which he had believed and which he had strived to preserve in personal relations with the head of the Soviet government: mutual trust in each other’s personal assurances.”

To Kennedy, Dobrynin looked “extremely concerned.” He stood by his earlier statement: as far as he knew, there were no missiles in Cuba. He also improvised, assuring Robert Kennedy that Khrushchev valued personal relations with his brother. All he had to go on were Khrushchev’s recent official statements. Whatever trust the Kennedy brothers had had in their Soviet counterparts—John in Khrushchev and Robert in Dobrynin—was now gone. But they still had nothing to guide them in predicting Soviet behavior except the words of the Soviet ambassador in Washington, who they correctly guessed was being kept in the dark by his own government.

As he was bidding farewell, Kennedy asked Dobrynin the question that had brought him to the Soviet Embassy: “What sorts of orders did the captains of the Soviet ships bound for Cuba have, in light of President Kennedy’s speech yesterday and the declaration which he had just signed about the inadmissibility of bringing offensive weapons to Cuba?” Dobrynin, who knew nothing about the instructions sent to the ships from Moscow the previous night, as he had known nothing about the missiles, told Kennedy that as far as he knew, the captains were following their usual instructions, “not to obey any unlawful demands to stop or be searched on the open sea, as a violation of international norms of freedom of navigation.” “I don’t know how all this will end, for we intend to stop your ships,” said Robert Kennedy before leaving the Soviet embassy. “But that would be an act of war,” responded Dobrynin. As he remembered later, Robert “shook his head and left.”[1]

The lines of communication between the two sides were broken, signals received were unclear, and those they sent themselves were often misunderstood by the other side. They were moving in the dark, hoping not to stumble into each other, but unconsciously speeding on a collision course.